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Published by

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Estimated reading time

3 min

Added on

2025-07-28

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/football/2025/jul/27/emma-hayes-ian-wright-shine-itv-bbc-euro-2025-final>

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Sarina Wiegman's team playing disjointedly, yet rescued by moments of inspiration and fortune. It is why "Proper England", to use the Lionesses' Euro 2025 mission statement, wins record audiences, an expected worldwide audience of 46 million dragged through Sunday night drama, putting Poldark and Mr Darcy to shame.

Across the [BBC](#) and ITV, Euro 2025 coverage has not been nearly so happy-clappy as the BBC's Team GB-Beebies, sub-Henman Hill Olympics cheerleading. Perhaps the cruelty of football as a game precludes that. Once the game is afoot, there are few hiding places. Still, there has been a cheeriness to both channels' female lead presenters – Laura Woods for ITV, Gabby Logan for BBC – so rarely seen in the male equivalent.

None of the sardonic shrugging of a Gary Lineker, or for older viewers, Des Lynam, little English reserve. Decades of [male national team failure](#) made that a default setting, as did hammering players and managers alike. By contrast, the Lionesses had reached a third major final in a row, and [as repeat Euro champions](#) are an actual success story a nation can get fully behind. There's very little to hammer.

Both choosing a lengthy buildup, ITV stole a 10-minute march, going early with the camera zooming to Woods in the centre circle of St Jakob-Park, Basel. "Are you ready to do it all over again?" she asked, soon enough alongside the former Chelsea and current USA coach Emma Hayes, the ex-England international Karen Carney and Ian Wright, the former England striker having resumed his role as women's football favourite uncle. "It's nothing to do with me," Wrighty replied when depicted as a lucky charm. "They've made it hard, I'm just pleased to be here."

"To be honest, they're the best," the never-less-than-honest Hayes said of the hot favourites Spain. By now, the BBC had kicked off with a good-luck message from Harry Kane, before then mashing up footage of England's progress with Focus Is Power, by Self Esteem, the south Yorkshire musician telling the camera: "A little girl in England can grow up and say I want to be a footballer – the impossible made possible."

Logan was joined by the former Lionesses Ellen White and Steph Houghton and the former Manchester City player Nedum Onuoha. "In Sarina, we trust," White said as news of Wiegman's team selection arrived. Still more than a full hour to kick-off, including some of that soft-focus performance poetry beloved on such sporting occasions by TV execs. It dragged. Eventually Wrighty admitted: "Yeah, I'm getting nervous now."

It was not an entirely wasted hour. On ITV, a reminder of what women's football fought off, footage showing the 1970s legend Rodney Marsh and the late doyen of football journalism Brian Glanville's rank dismissiveness, ending with the Lioness Beth Mead telling those who lived through this: "You helped change the game for the better, be proud of that." "It's laughable now," said Wrighty, visibly embarrassed by football-man forefathers.

Finally, time for the commentators, Robyn Cowen on BBC, Seb Hutchinson on ITV, two safe pairs of hands, the former England goalkeeper Rachel Finnis-Brown alongside Cowen, the fine tactical toothcomb of Lucy Ward, once of Leeds, accompanying Hutchinson.

"England almost finding a way through," Hutchinson's baritone growled during one early near-miss. Commentating on such matches isn't easy; willing on one side while trying to maintain a soupçon of neutrality, all while hoping to nail the moments that matter.

"It's a gorgeous Spain goal," Cowen said as Mariona Caldentey scored. "Too easy," Ward said. By half-time, despite the talismanic Chloe Kelly replacing James, the mood was sombre. "We've been totally off it," Wrighty lamented. "England lack freshness," explained Hayes.

Alessia Russo's goal – and name – received the same reaction from both commentators. "Russooooo!" roared Robyn. So did Seb. "Never write England off!" he bellowed. By now his growls were recalling the great Brian Moore. Cowen said "time seems to be slowing down" as extra time approached. "England were never going to make this comfortable, I can't bear it," Woods said. Hayes said: "I love it."

As the cost of mistakes grew, the game's entertainment values became more slasher movie than high-class narrative. "I'm not sure this is good for our health," Cowen said before the unfailing dopamine hit of penalties arrived. "I just can't do it again," White said.

"A huge moment for Hannah Hampton," Cowen said after the keeper's first save. "Calm Niamh Charles," Hutchinson roared before next: "Hampton, all the way." England had grabbed the initiative. Cue Kelly. "The legendary Lionesses," Hutchinson said. "Now that is proper English," Cowen said. Both had successfully landed the words they had waited so long to be able to say.

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